FOR PASTORS, CHURCH MEMBERS, AND THE BELIEVER ON A SCHOOL BOARD

A Christian's Guide to Corporal Punishment

The rod verses read honestly in the King James, the fruit test of Hebrews 12:11 and Matthew 7:16 applied to the research, what the churches have said, and a page for the believer on a school board. By a former minister who has worked on this for fifteen years.

Version 2026-10-29 · Every verse checked against the King James text; every research finding and church position carries the id of a verified claim in the project's facts registry · The web version, with live links, is at earthpilot.org/kids/kit/a-christians-guide/ · Free to use and share (CC BY 4.0)

Who this is for. Pastors, Sunday school teachers, church members, and the believer who sits on a school board in one of the seventeen states where a public school employee may still paddle a child. Every verse is quoted from the King James Bible, and every figure is tied to a verified source in the project's facts registry. If you have three minutes and nothing else, read aloud the page near the end that was written for it.

Why a minister is writing this

I was an ordained minister in another life. I have degrees in psychology and urban planning, and I want to be plain that I am not a psychologist; I am someone who studied the subject and then spent fifteen years reading what the researchers found. I came to school corporal punishment by accident, around 2011, when an education blog I wrote had done well enough that people sent me things. One of the things they sent me was a federal count of children paddled in public schools. In those years the federal count was more than a hundred thousand children a year. The last count is under twenty thousand. (crdc-national-trend-2013-to-2022; crdc-national-total-2023-24-computed) I have had a part in that. The school boards that stopped on their own had the larger part.

In those fifteen years the conversation that mattered most was never the one about the research. It was the one in a church fellowship hall, or on the phone with a superintendent who told me, gently, that the Bible says what it says. He was right that it says it. I am writing this because I think

the Bible also tells us how to judge what we do with it, and because the people who still decide whether a child gets paddled are, in most of these districts, people who pray before the meeting.

So this is not a case against scripture. It is a case made from inside it, by someone who has preached from it and still reads it. I am not going to tell you the rod verses mean something other than what they say. I am going to ask you to do what scripture itself asks: look at the fruit.

What discipline means in scripture

Start with the word. In English, "discipline" and "disciple" are the same root; the Latin behind both means a pupil, a learner, and the instruction given to one. A disciple is someone being taught. When the risen Christ sends the eleven out, the King James renders his command as teaching:

> *Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you. (Matthew 28:19-20)*

Discipline, in the sense the Bible cares about, is what makes a learner. The question for any method of discipline is whether the child learns.

Paul says the same thing to fathers, and he says it with a warning on both sides:

> *And, ye fathers, provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord. (Ephesians 6:4)*

Nurture is raising; admonition is instruction and warning. The verse has a prohibition in front of its command. Do not provoke the child to wrath. Then raise and teach. A method that produces an angry child has failed the first half of the verse before we get to the second.

The writer to the Hebrews is the one who gives us the test. He has just compared God's discipline of believers to a father's discipline of a son, and he does not pretend that discipline feels good:

> *Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness unto them which are exercised thereby. (Hebrews 12:11)*

Read that carefully, because the whole of this booklet rests on it. Chastening is judged by what it yields afterward. Not by whether it hurt, not by whether the child was quiet for the rest of the afternoon, not by whether it was done in love. By the fruit, later, in the person who was exercised by it. Peaceable righteousness is the fruit that counts. If a method of discipline does not yield that, the verse gives us no reason to keep it.

And then there is the proverb that every parent knows and that has nothing to do with striking anyone:

> *Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it. (Proverbs 22:6)*

Train. The teacher's word.

The rod passages, read honestly

Here are the verses, in the King James, that people have in mind when they say the Bible permits paddling. I am quoting all of them because I do not want to be accused of hiding one.

> *He that spareth his rod hateth his son: but he that loveth him chasteneth him betimes. (Proverbs 13:24)*

> *Foolishness is bound in the heart of a child; but the rod of correction shall drive it far from him. (Proverbs 22:15)*

> *Withhold not correction from the child: for if thou beatest him with the rod, he shall not die. Thou shalt beat him with the rod, and shalt deliver his soul from hell. (Proverbs 23:13-14)*

> *The rod and reproof give wisdom: but a child left to himself bringeth his mother to shame. (Proverbs 29:15)*

> *Chasten thy son while there is hope, and let not thy soul spare for his crying. (Proverbs 19:18)*

Let me say plainly what they say. They say a rod. They say beat. They say that a father who loves his son corrects him, and corrects him early ("betimes" is the old word for early and diligently; newer translations say he is careful to discipline him). They are not metaphors that a modern reader has misunderstood; the plain sense is physical correction by a parent in an ancient Israelite household, and I am not going to tell you otherwise.

Christian scholars do differ about them, and you should know where, without anyone telling you the matter is closed. Some hold that the rod in Proverbs is the shepherd's rod of Psalm 23 ("thy rod and thy staff they comfort me"), an emblem of guidance and authority rather than an instrument. Some note that these are proverbs, which the tradition has always read as wisdom sayings rather than promises or commands, in the way that "a soft answer turneth away wrath" is counsel and not

a guarantee. Some argue over the age of the one being corrected, since the word the King James renders "child" is also used of young men; I mention that only to say that I do not rest anything on it, and I distrust word-study arguments offered as settled from either side. And some hold that the plain sense stands and that a parent may use it. These are real disagreements among people who love the same book. I am not going to settle them here.

I do not need to, for two reasons.

First, every one of these verses is addressed to a parent about that parent's own child. "His son." "Thy son." Not one of them is addressed to a school, a magistrate, a government, or an employee of the state holding someone else's child. Whatever a Christian parent concludes about the rod at home, the verses say nothing about a principal with a board and a signed form. The question in front of a school board is not whether the Bible permits a father to correct his son. It is whether a public employee may strike a child who is not his, with a wooden paddle, as a matter of district policy. Proverbs does not speak to that.

Second, and this is the heart of it, scripture tells us how to judge any discipline, including this one, and it does not say "judge it by whether it is mentioned in Proverbs." It says judge it by what it yields.

One more honest note. Hebrews 12:6 says the Lord "scourgeth every son whom he receiveth." The writer is using the hardest image his readers knew for how God deals with those he loves. I am not going to pretend that verse is tender. I am going to point out that five verses later the same writer tells us how to know whether chastening is of God: by the peaceable fruit it yields afterward. He gives us the image and the test together. We are not free to keep one and drop the other.

The fruit test

Jesus gave the test for judging a teacher, and the church has always applied it more widely than to teachers alone:

> *Ye shall know them by their fruits. Do men gather grapes of thorns, or figs of thistles? Even so every good tree bringeth forth good fruit; but a corrupt tree bringeth forth evil fruit. (Matthew 7:16-17)*

So let us look at the fruit. Not the fruit in one child, or in your own childhood, or in mine. Many people my age were paddled in school and will tell you they turned out fine, and that proves exactly what one tree proves about an orchard. The fruit test asks about the orchard. For school paddling we have the orchard: tens of thousands of children followed by researchers over decades, in studies that compared those who were hit with those who were not. Here is what they found, one finding at a time, each with its source in the facts registry.

Across the whole research base, the fruit runs one way. In 2016 two researchers gathered every usable study of spanking they could find: seventy-five studies covering more than one hundred and sixty thousand children. They examined seventeen outcomes. Spanking was significantly associated with thirteen of them, and every one of the thirteen was in the direction of harm: more aggression, more mental health problems, more later victimization by physical abuse. Not one outcome ran in the direction of benefit. The one thing people most expect spanking to do, make the child comply right now, did not reach significance. (study-gershoff-grogan-kaylor-2016)

In schools specifically, the same. The 2016 analysis was about parents. In 2022 a team did the same work for school corporal punishment alone. Across twenty-one studies and more than sixty-seven thousand children, school corporal punishment went with more acting out. It went with more inward trouble, the anxiety and withdrawal that teachers call "quiet" and later call depression. And across twenty studies and nearly a million children it went with lower school performance. The thing we tell ourselves paddling is for, a child who settles down and learns, is the thing it is associated with less of. (study-visser-2022-school-meta-analysis)

The children who were paddled, grown up. In 2019 researchers found more than eight hundred young adults from the nineteen states where school corporal punishment was then legal and matched those who had been paddled at school with those who had not, like for like on everything else they could measure. The ones who had been paddled had lower high school grade point averages. They had more depressive symptoms. And they were more likely to say they intended to spank their own children. (study-gershoff-sattler-holden-2019)

Put the depression finding beside Paul:

> *Fathers, provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged. (Colossians 3:21)*

Discouraged. The King James chose that word for what happens to a child who is provoked, and the researchers, who were not reading Colossians, found it in the data two thousand years later. And put the last finding, that paddled children grow up intending to paddle, beside Galatians:

> *Be not deceived; God is not mocked: for whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap. (Galatians 6:7)*

And nothing on the other side. It is fair to ask whether the schools that stopped paddling fell apart. No study has found that ending corporal punishment increases misbehavior. No study has found that using it improves behavior. As of this writing there is no published before-and-after study of a state or district ban that shows harm from stopping, and the American Academy of Pediatrics, in its 2023 statement calling for corporal punishment to be abolished in every school in every state, argues from exactly that: no evidence of benefit, consistent evidence of harm. (evidence-no-post-ban-outcome-study; org-aap-2023-school-statement)

Let me be honest about what these studies are. Most are associations, not laboratory proofs. No one can assign children at random to be hit, so no one has. A careful reader can always say that the children who were paddled were already different. The answer is that the 2019 study matched for that as well as anyone can, and that in every study, of every design, in every decade, the direction is the same. Thorns do not yield grapes in one study and figs in the next.

By their fruits ye shall know them. The paddle fails the test that scripture itself sets. Not my test. Hebrews' test. Matthew's test.

Prove all things

Some believers hear "look at the research" as an invitation to doubt scripture. I hear it as obedience to scripture:

> *Prove all things; hold fast that which is good. (1 Thessalonians 5:21)*

Prove, in the old sense: test. Paul does not say prove the things you are unsure of. He says prove all things, and keep what passes. The researchers who followed those children did the proving. They did not set out to attack anyone's faith; most of them were not thinking about faith at all. They tested a practice and reported what it yielded. Reading their report is not doubting the Bible. It is doing what the Bible tells us to do with every practice we have inherited, including the ones our grandparents were sure of.

And Paul adds the other half: hold fast that which is good. The next section is about what is good, which is to say what passed the test.

The teacher's work instead

If discipline means teaching, then the replacement for the paddle is not nothing. It is the teacher's work, and it has three parts that any Sunday school teacher will recognize.

Teach the expectation first. A child cannot keep a rule he has not been taught, and most misbehavior in a classroom is a rule the child does not yet hold, or holds and cannot yet keep. The rules are taught, shown, practiced, and taught again, the way anything else in the building is taught.

Give a consequence that fits. A consequence teaches when the child can see the line from what he did to what happens next: the thing broken is repaired, the time taken is given back, the privilege misused is lost for a while. A paddling teaches a different lesson: that the biggest person in the

room may hurt the smaller one when he is angry enough. Children learn that lesson well. The 2016 analysis found it in the aggression numbers.

Practice. Self-control is a skill, not a decision, and skills are built by rehearsal with someone who corrects gently and often. That is what "chasteneth him betimes" looks like when the chastening is teaching: early, often, and before the thing has gone wrong.

This is not a hope. It is the most-tested part of the whole field. A 2016 review gathered fifty-four controlled studies of classroom management programs, the kind where a school adopts a way of teaching behavior and is compared with schools that did not, and found that students in those programs did better academically, behaviorally, and socially, with the programs built around social and emotional skills contributing most. (alt-classroom-management-korpershoek-2016) In a five-year randomized trial across thirty-seven Maryland elementary schools, the schools that adopted school-wide positive behavior supports had fewer suspensions and fewer office referrals, and a child in one of those schools was a third less likely to be sent to the office at all. (alt-pbis-bradshaw-rcts) Fifty-four controlled studies on one side; no controlled study of benefit on the other. That is what "hold fast that which is good" looks like with the numbers in.

For a Sunday school teacher. You already do this. You have never paddled a child in your classroom and the room has not fallen apart, because you teach the rules, you notice the child who is about to lose the thread, you move him next to you, you give him a job, you tell his mother what went well. When a parent in your congregation says a child "needs" the paddle, you are a witness that a room full of children can be taught without it. Say so. A church that raises its children for an hour on Sunday without striking them has already answered the question for the other five days.

For a principal. Your district's policy may permit it. Nothing requires you to use it, and the boards that have stopped did not stop by replacing the paddle with nothing. They replaced it with taught expectations, a tiered response that starts with the classroom teacher and reaches you only when it should, and a record of what was tried. The training and the ninety-day transition are in the Safe Discipline Program kit, free, at earthpilot.org/kids/kit/. Start with the records: count your paddlings by school, by grade, by race and sex and disability status, and look at who is on the list. Most principals who do that do not need the rest of the argument.

What the churches have said

Christians sometimes assume their denomination is silent on this or, worse, that it is for it. Here is what I could verify on each church's own website, with the year and the name of the action. I have left out everything I could only find in a news report, except where I say so.

Presbyterian Church (U.S.A.). The 220th General Assembly, meeting in Pittsburgh in 2012, adopted a Resolution Against Corporal Punishment. It encourages members to adopt discipline methods "at home, in schools, pediatric facilities, and institutions" and child care facilities "that do

not include corporal punishment of children," and it "calls upon all states to enact licensing laws prohibiting corporal punishment in schools and day and residential childcare facilities." The church's own summary of that Assembly records the vote as three hundred thirty-four to three hundred six, the closest social justice vote of the meeting. It was not unanimous. It was a church arguing in the open and deciding. (org-pcusa-2012-resolution-against-corporal-punishment)

The United Methodist Church. The 2004 General Conference adopted "Discipline Children Without Corporal Punishment," which the church readopted in 2012: "The United Methodist Church encourages its members to adopt discipline methods that do not include corporal punishment of their children." The church's website now marks that resolution as expired, and the current Book of Resolutions lists a separate resolution, "Prohibit Corporal Punishment in Schools and Childcare Facilities," whose text I was not able to read on the church's site. In 2024, when two verses from Proverbs were quoted in the Oklahoma Senate against a bill to end paddling of students with disabilities, the United Methodist bishop for Oklahoma wrote in The Oklahoman that his church does not condone corporal punishment. (org-umc-2004-discipline-children-without-corporal-punishment; org-umc-oklahoma-bishop-2024-column)

Evangelical Lutheran Church in America. The ELCA Church Council adopted a social message on Child Protection on November 12, 2025. It says that worshiping communities "are called to be safe spaces, free of violence," where "the use of force," and it names "physical discipline" in particular, is "specifically prohibited," and it asks synods to provide parents with resources on "effective forms of nonphysical discipline." It speaks to churches and parents, not to schools, and I cite it for what it says and no more. (org-elca-2025-child-protection-social-message)

The Catholic Church. There is no national church law on it that I could find; the rule is set diocese by diocese, and the dioceses I checked set it the same way. The Diocese of Des Moines, in its school policy on corporal punishment: "Corporal punishment is prohibited." The Archdiocese of Baltimore, in its school policy on discipline: "Catholic schools' personnel may never use corporal punishment." (org-catholic-diocese-des-moines-policy-466; org-catholic-archdiocese-baltimore-discipline-policy) In 2011 the Catholic press reported that the last Catholic school in the country still paddling, in New Orleans, ended the practice after Archbishop Gregory Aymond said he did not believe the teachings of the Catholic Church could condone corporal punishment and that he could not imagine Jesus paddling anyone. I have that from the Catholic News Agency's report, not from the archdiocese, and I say so. (org-catholic-new-orleans-2011-aymond-reported)

Churches with no position. Honesty requires the other list. The Southern Baptist Convention's resolutions library, searched on the convention's own site for "corporal punishment" and for "spanking," returns no resolution on either. The Episcopal Church's Acts of Convention database, which holds every General Convention action from 1973 to 2024, returns no record for "corporal." The Christian Church (Disciples of Christ) site returns nothing. The Church of the Brethren's 1999 resolution on Children and Violence does not mention it. (org-denominations-no-position-corporal-

punishment-2026-10) Silence is not endorsement. It means the question has not come to the floor. If you belong to one of those bodies, it can, and the Presbyterians showed what the vote looks like.

I will add one thing that is not a resolution. The Catholic dioceses I checked prohibit the paddle in their own schools, and the Catholic press reported in 2011 that the last Catholic school in the country to use it had stopped. Same scripture. Different board.

For the believer on a school board

You did not run for the board to be a theologian. But you are a Christian, and you are the one who votes, so this page is for you.

The sentence. Here is the whole policy that more than eleven hundred school boards in the seventeen permitting states have already adopted, in one form or another: *The Board prohibits the use of corporal punishment in the District.* One sentence, in a policy code your board already has. (districts-prohibiting-boards-17-states-2026-10; law-states-permitting-count) The boards that have adopted it are not in Massachusetts. They are your neighbors, in Alabama and Arkansas and Georgia and Texas and Tennessee and Missouri and Oklahoma. The model policy, the motion, and the words for staff and families are in the kit.

What you will be told. You will be told it is a parent's right. The vote is not about what a parent may do at home; Proverbs is addressed to parents and this policy is not. The vote is about whether an employee of your district may strike someone else's child with a board as a matter of policy. You will be told it works. Ask for the study. There is none that shows benefit, and there are seventy-five studies of the practice on the other side. You will be told that the Bible says it. Hand them this booklet, and ask them to read Hebrews 12:11 with you.

The records to ask for. Before the vote, ask the superintendent, in writing, for five things. The number of corporal punishment incidents in each of the last three years, by school, by grade, and by race, sex, and disability status, which is what the district already reports to the federal Civil Rights Data Collection. The current policy and the handbook language, with every consent or opt-out form in use. Any complaint, grievance, or legal claim arising from corporal punishment in the last ten years, and what it cost. The insurance carrier's position on the practice. And what training the staff who administer it have received. Boards that ask for these records rarely need the rest of the argument, because the list of who gets paddled is not the list of who misbehaves most. In the 2021-22 federal count, boys were about half of enrollment and four fifths of the children struck, and Black children were fifteen of every hundred enrolled and twenty-six of every hundred struck, which is why the United States Secretary of Education wrote to every governor in 2023 asking states to end it. (crdc-boys-share-2021-22; crdc-black-students-share-2021-22; law-cardona-letter-2023)

Who is already on record. The American Academy of Pediatrics, in 2023, calling for abolition in every state. Seventy-nine organizations, including the national associations of pediatricians,

psychologists, school principals, parents and teachers, in an open letter in 2016. Your own denomination, if it is one of the ones above. (org-aap-2023-school-statement; org-nwlc-open-letter-2016)

The vote. Move the sentence. Set the effective date ninety days out so the training happens first. Direct the superintendent to report the referral counts at each meeting after the change, so that your district produces the record the researchers have been waiting for. And if the vote is close, remember that the Presbyterian vote was close too, and the church is still standing.

A page to read aloud

I was a minister. I have spent fifteen years on the question of whether a school should paddle a child, and I want to give you the whole of what I have learned in the time it takes to read this page.

The Bible speaks of the rod. It says a father who loves his son corrects him. I am not here to tell you those verses mean something else. I am here to tell you what the same Bible says about how to judge any correction.

It says: "Now no chastening for the present seemeth to be joyous, but grievous: nevertheless afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness." Judge the chastening by its fruit, afterward, in the child.

It says: "Ye shall know them by their fruits."

It says: "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good."

So we looked at the fruit. Researchers followed tens of thousands of children, in seventy-five studies, and compared the ones who were hit with the ones who were not. Of seventeen things they measured, thirteen were worse for the children who were hit. Not one was better. In the schools, the children who were paddled did worse in class, not better. They grew up with more depression, and Paul wrote, "Provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged." They grew up more likely to paddle their own children, and Paul wrote, "Whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap."

No study has ever found that stopping made a school worse. Fifty-four controlled studies have found that teaching children how to behave, and practicing it with them, makes a school better.

That is the fruit. By scripture's own test, the paddle fails.

Every rod verse in Proverbs is addressed to a parent about that parent's own child. Not one is addressed to a school. The question before a school board is whether an employee of the district may strike someone else's child with a board. Proverbs does not answer that. The fruit does.

The Presbyterians voted on this and said no. The Methodists said no. More than eleven hundred school boards in the states that still allow it have said no, in one sentence: the Board prohibits the use of corporal punishment in the District.

Discipline means teaching. A disciple is a learner. Let us teach them.

Passages cited, in order

- Matthew 28:19-20, "Go ye therefore, and teach all nations"
- Ephesians 6:4, "provoke not your children to wrath: but bring them up in the nurture and admonition of the Lord"
- Hebrews 12:11, "afterward it yieldeth the peaceable fruit of righteousness"
- Proverbs 22:6, "Train up a child in the way he should go"
- Proverbs 13:24, "he that loveth him chasteneth him betimes"
- Proverbs 22:15, "the rod of correction shall drive it far from him"
- Proverbs 23:13-14, "Withhold not correction from the child"
- Proverbs 29:15, "The rod and reproof give wisdom"
- Proverbs 19:18, "Chasten thy son while there is hope"
- Psalm 23:4, "thy rod and thy staff they comfort me"
- Hebrews 12:6, "whom the Lord loveth he chasteneth"
- Matthew 7:16-17, "Ye shall know them by their fruits"
- Colossians 3:21, "provoke not your children to anger, lest they be discouraged"
- Galatians 6:7, "whatsoever a man soweth, that shall he also reap"
- 1 Thessalonians 5:21, "Prove all things; hold fast that which is good"

All quotations are from the King James Version, which is in the public domain, and each was checked against the text before it went in. The research and church positions cited by id in parentheses are verified claims in the project's facts registry at earthpilot.org/kids/resources/, each with its primary source.

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